projects worth up to Rs 50 crore.

The government has simultaneously attempted to push administrative reform through measures aimed at reducing corruption, increasing transparency and cutting bureaucratic delays. Among them is an e-registration system for land and property registration, while individuals above 80 years of age are now eligible for home registration services.

"Zero tolerance" for corruption is another key plank of Choudhary's agenda. On May 30, he suspended IAS officers Abhilasha Kumari Sharma and Yogesh Kumar Sagar, alleged beneficiaries of a tender-manipulation scam. He has also sought to bring technology into the state's anti-corruption framework by introducing AI-based scrutiny of engineering estimates across departments—a move officials say directly targets inflated project costs. "In many places, where an estimate used to be around Rs 1 lakh, we have already started seeing a reduction of 5-6 per cent. Once AI becomes integrated into governance, duplication and inflated projections will disappear," the CM said.

For years, the BJP functioned in Bihar as the junior partner in Nitish's coalitions, despite its growing electoral heft. The saffron party supplied political energy and organisational muscle; Nitish supplied administrative legitimacy. But by the end of Nitish's long tenure, the administrative machine had acquired a certain lethargy.

Inside party circles, there had long been frustration that Bihar's political discourse remained trapped between nostalgia and caste arithmetic while younger voters increasingly cared about visible delivery—roads, policing, urban infrastructure, jobs and digital responsiveness. Party strategists believed that if they ever acquired greater operational control over the state apparatus, they would need to create an impression of kinetic governance. Choudhary, with his naturally combative style, emerged as a useful embodiment of that approach.

To operationalise that shift, Choudhary has installed his own handpicked officers in the CM secretariat, shifting two senior IAS officers known for their proximity to the Nitish regime to other departments while a third has moved on central deputation.

SAMRAT'S CHALLENGES

Governance speed faces the harder test of delivery

- **Managing Bihar's Rs 3.17 lakh crore budget amid a massive social welfare expenditure burden**
- **Generating new revenue streams while retaining prohibition**
- **Turning industrial outreach into real economic activity and jobs**
- **Meeting expectations after publicly promising nearly Rs 5 lakh crore in investment proposals within a year**
- **Addressing migration, unemployment and Bihar's developmental lag**
- **Converting 'muscular governance' into durable institutional systems**
- **Sustaining administrative momentum without causing bureaucratic fatigue**
- **Preserving Nitish's governance legacy while building a distinct BJP-era administrative identity**

REALITY CHECK

Yet, for all the muscular messaging and administrative urgency, Choudhary faces formidable challenges. Bihar's Rs 3.17 lakh crore budget for FY26 is heavily burdened by committed spending, with salaries, pensions, interest payments and welfare obligations consuming a substantial share of resources. At the same time, Choudhary cannot politically afford to dilute prohibition—one of the defining policies of the Nitish era. The liquor ban has not only deprived Bihar of a major potential revenue stream, but has also tied down significant police and judicial resources in enforcement and litigation.

The CM, therefore, is exploring alternative revenue models, such as the expansion of toll taxation to strengthen the non-tax revenue base. Simultaneously, the government is aggressively courting private investment. On May 17, Choudhary's meeting with Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani in Patna was an attempt to establish direct channels with India's largest industrial groups and project Bihar as investment-ready. The group has already committed major investments in the state, including the Pirpainti power project.

A day after the meeting, on May 18, Choudhary announced that Bihar was now moving beyond the old developmental vocabulary of "*sadak, bijli aur moolbhoot suvidha*" (road, electricity and basic amenities). "By the time the NDA government completes one year in office, investment proposals worth nearly Rs 5 lakh crore will be implemented in Bihar."

On the CM's desk lie three TV remote controls, resting within his easy reach. The symbolism is hard to miss: in a state being governed through centralised command, the controls appear firmly in his hands. ■